Exploring Voter Bias: How Minority and Non-Minority Win Rates Compare in Canadian Elections

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Introduction

Canada is widely perceived to be a diverse and multicultural society, welcoming toward immigrants and ethnic minorities. But do its institutions embody these principles of inclusion? In the two decades following the Canadian Multiculturalism Act, 1988, representation of ethnic minorities improved in the House of Commons. However, visible minorities remained particularly under-represented (Black 2006, 555). This is a significant issue worth looking into further, as Canada's immigrant population continues to grow, and ethnic minorities become a larger group in society. It is important to ensure the machinery of democracy allows for their fair representation and access to the machinery of government.

According to the 2021 census, Canada's South Asian population was 7.1%, Chinese was 4.7%, and Black was 4.3%. Together these were the largest minority groups, making up 16.1% of the total population (Statistics Canada 2022). As Bird (2010) says, minority members in the House of Commons are more likely to discuss ethnic issues than non-minority MPs, even if they are from highly ethnic ridings. It is therefore crucial to explore whether there are any significant barriers for minority electoral candidates to win a seat in the House of Commons, based solely on their ethnic background.

Brief Literature Review

Jerome Black is one of the foremost scholars in minority outcomes in Canadian elections. His recent research has shown that following the 2025 election, there have been substantial increases in ethnic minority candidates, but declines in female and Indigenous candidates (Black 2025). Furthermore, his research finds that voter bias plays a limited role in determining

outcomes for minority candidates. Instead, party nomination and electoral district placement seem to be more important in determining electoral outcomes.

Other scholars, such as Lapointe et al. (2024), found that minority candidates running for the Liberal and Conservative parties were much more likely to be placed in highly competitive electoral districts. They conclude that minorities, but particularly LGBTQ2S+ and women candidates, are often sacrificial lambs. Finally, Bird (2010) finds no evidence of voter-level discrimination towards minority candidates. Instead, it is the strategic placement of ethnic minorities in electoral districts (particularly urban ones) that largely explains their win rates, which tend to be higher in more ethnically diverse ridings.

Goals of This Paper

This paper aims to explore the relationship between electoral outcomes and ethnic minorities in Canadian elections. Namely, to uncover whether there is a voter bias driving potential differences in minority versus non-minority win rates across the 2004-2025 federal elections. Using electoral data about the candidates in each election from Elections Canada, I will explore if there is a statistically significant difference in the rates at which minorities win compared to white candidates. I will also explore potential differences across time and by party. Examining differences in win rate by party may partly reflect overall win rates for that party, but may also contain an element of voter bias toward racialized candidates. It could also indicate that minorities are over-represented in difficult-to-win ridings, positioning some of them as sacrificial lambs.

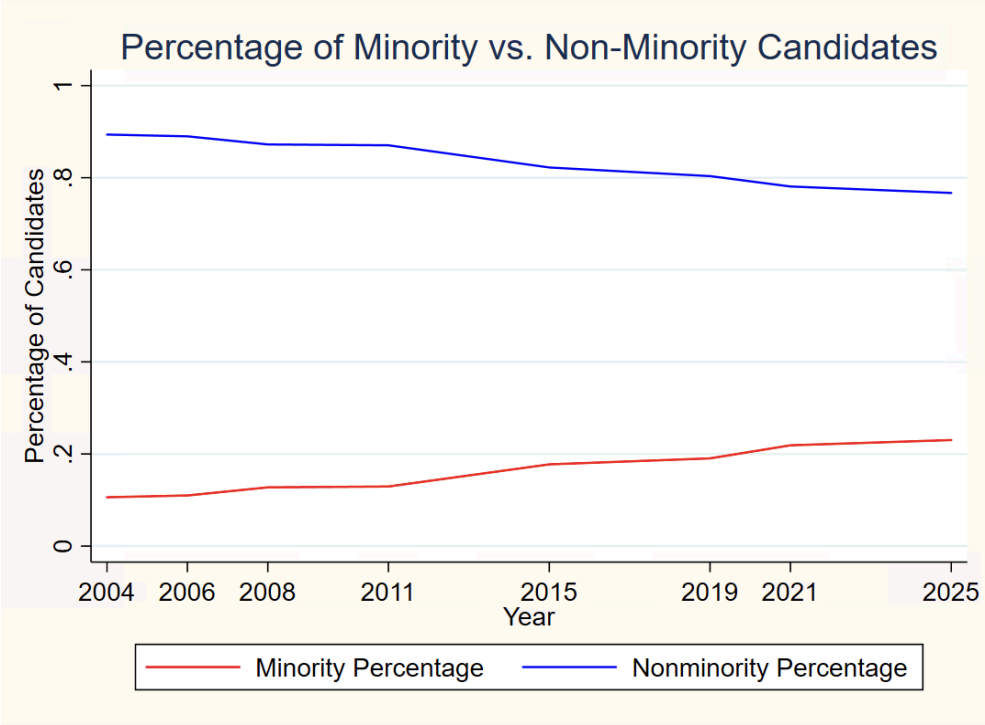
Results

Election Year								
	2004	2006	2008	2011	2015	2019	2021	2025
Elected MPs								
Minority Percentage	3.78	3.89	4.56	4.63	18.73	12.20	13.50	38.71
Non-Minority Percentage	8.32	8.29	8.09	8.09	8.37	12.97	11.87	33.99
Percentage Point Difference	-4.54	-4.40	-3.53	-3.45	10.36	-0.78	1.63	4.71
Candidates								
Minority Percentage	5.10	5.69	5.10	6.86	11.18	11.76	12.55	41.76
Non-Minority Percentage	10.20	10.09	10.20	9.87	10.16	10.05	9.91	29.51
Percentage Point Difference	-5.10	-4.40	-5.10	-3.01	1.01	1.71	2.64	12.25

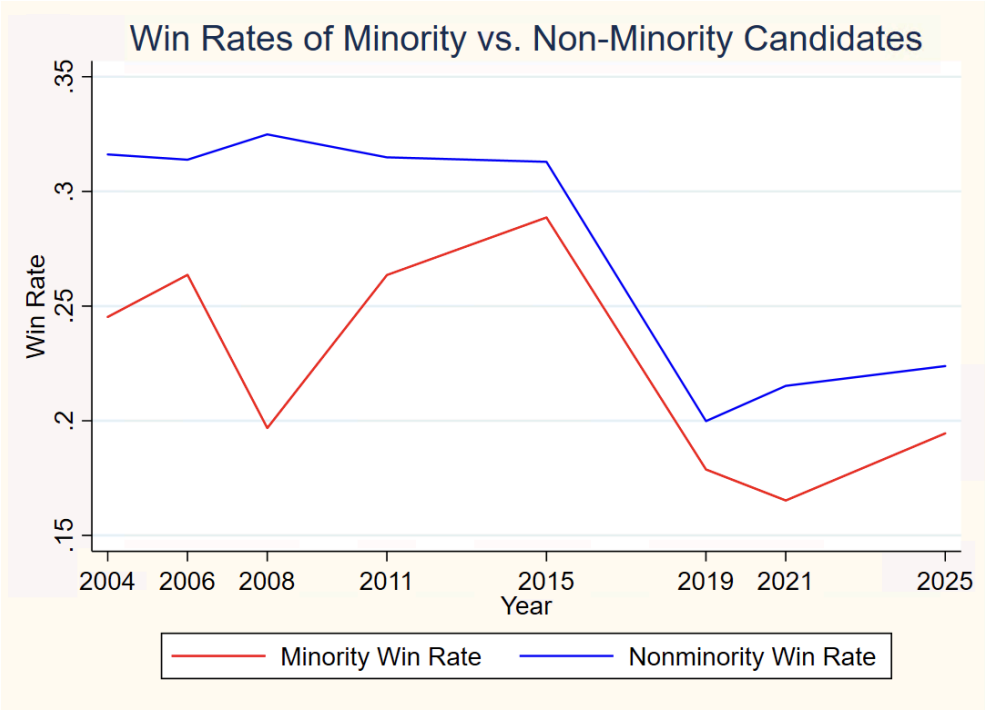
It is clear that the percentage of minority MPs has risen considerably over the last two decades, up to 39% after the 2025 election. This roughly reflects a trend towards increasing representation for minorities in the House of Commons. Furthermore, the percentage of minority candidates has also increased dramatically since the most recent election, up to 42%, exceeding a steady trend in previous years.

It is important to note that these numbers may reflect parties' strategic decisions about where to place minority candidates and how many to place, based on ethnic populations and careful calculations about how best to achieve a majority vote. However, they may also reflect

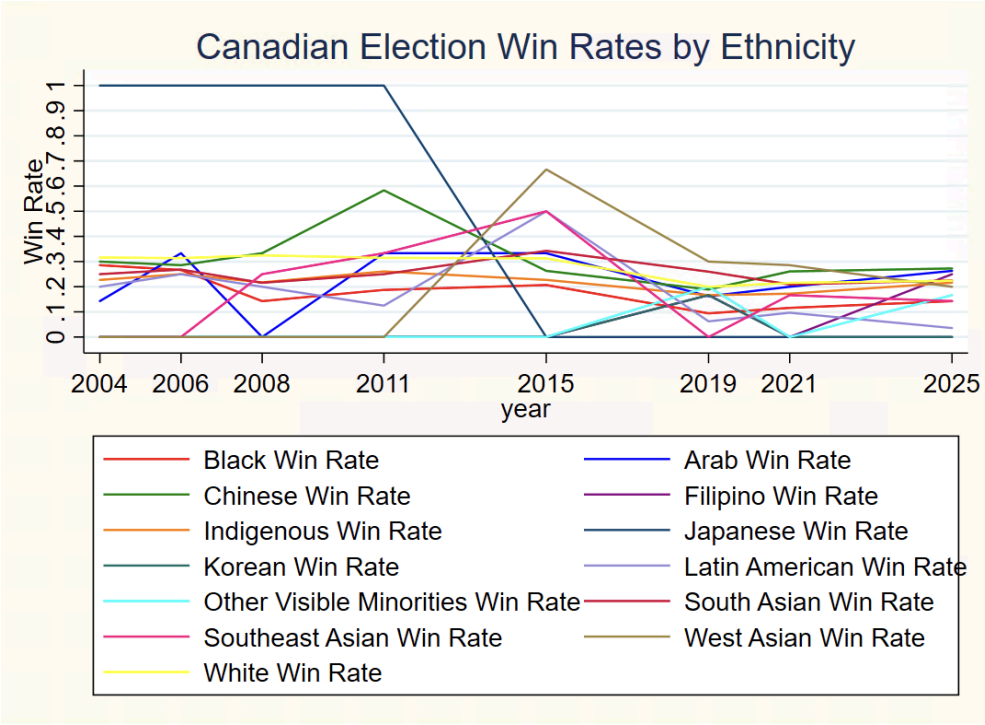
the ethnic makeup of Canada at the time, and the party's nomination choice may be aimed to match minority candidates with similarly ethnic ridings. Part of this change could reflect growing minority populations, particularly for the Arab (254% increase from 2001-2021), West Asian (214%), Filipino (207%) and Black (125%) groups (Statistics Canada 2023).



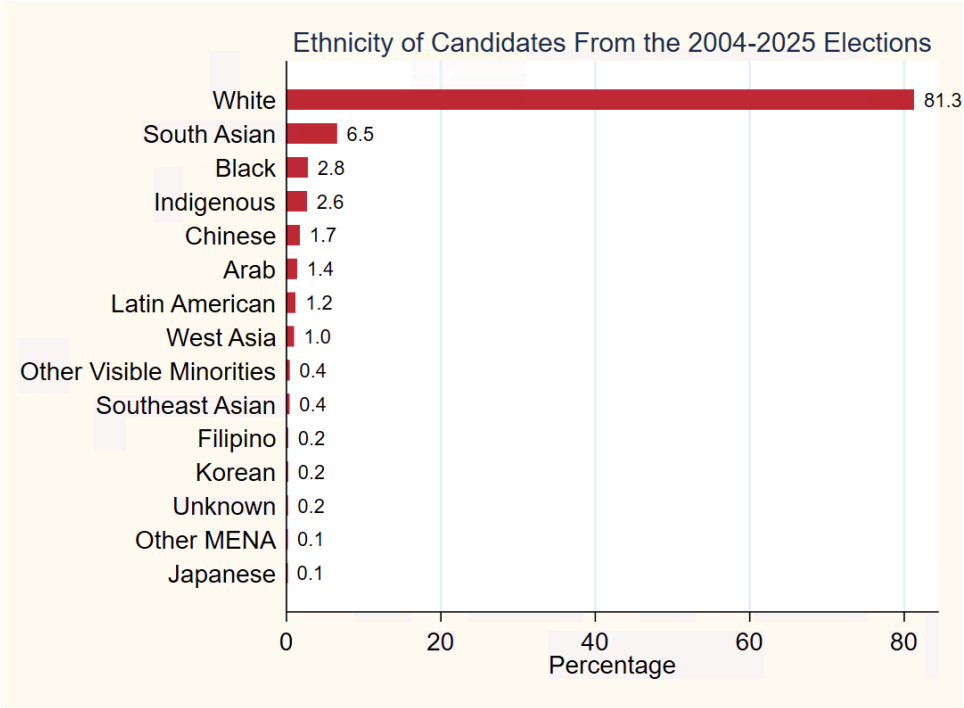
This graph depicts the percentage of minority and non-minority candidates running in each election year. The gap appears to have closed somewhat in recent years, however there is still a significant gap between 77% white candidates and 22% minority candidates, especially considering that 26.3% of the Canadian population in 2021 were ethnic minorities, and this number is projected to keep climbing (Elections Canada 2021).



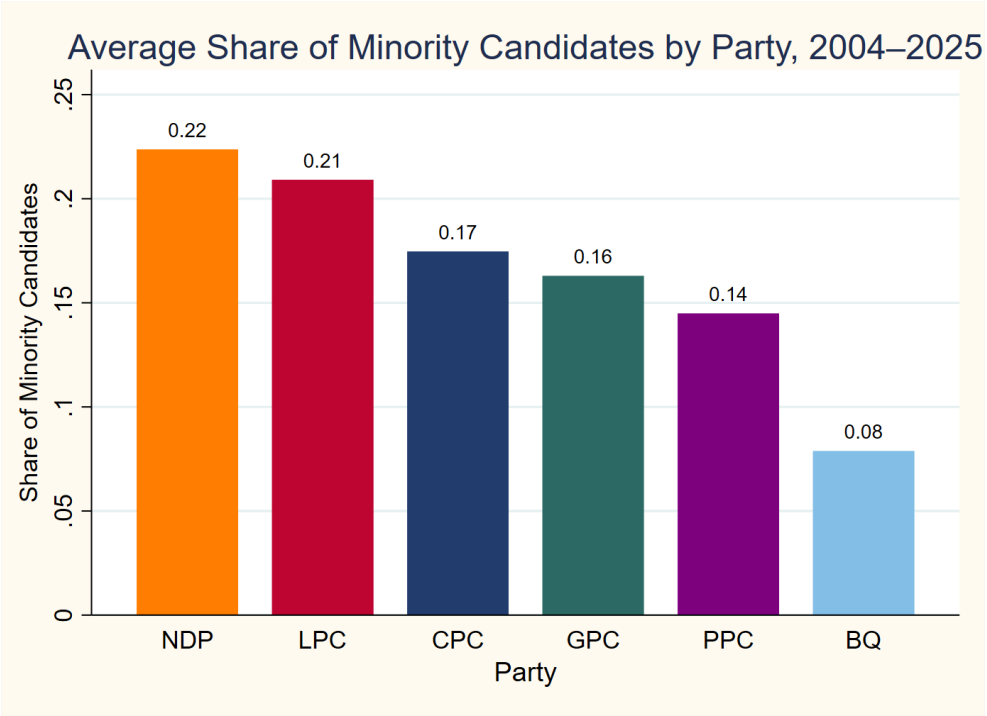
This graph shows the win rates for minority and non-minority candidates. This was calculated as the number of winning minority candidates, divided by the total number of minority candidates by year. The same was done for the non-minority line, but with non-minority values. It is evident that white candidates have always had higher win rates across the last 20 years of elections. The gap appears at its smallest in 2015 and 2019, before widening again in 2021 and 2025. While the exact cause of this is unknown, it could indicate a variety of causes. First, that parties are running more minority candidates in competitive electoral districts, leading to lower win rates. Second, that voter bias may be affecting minority outcomes. To attempt to untangle which of these effects is at play, further analysis is needed.



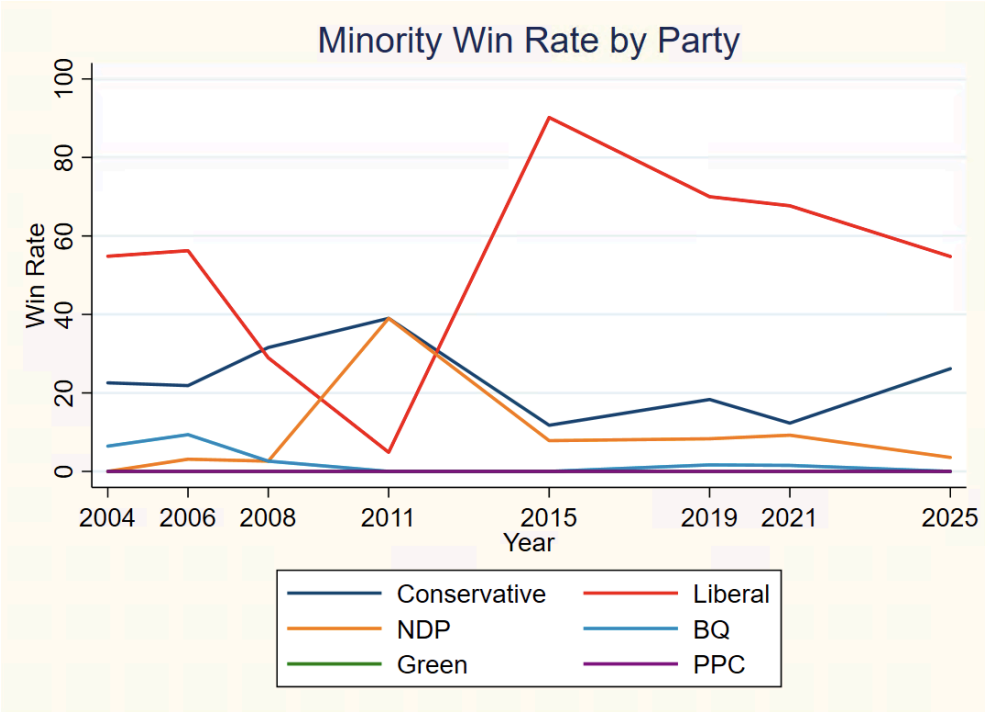
This graph depicts the win rates of each ethnic group throughout the years. This was achieved by calculating the number of winners per each minority, divided by the total number of candidates in that ethnic group running that year. Some results are striking, such as 100% of Japanese candidates winning a seat up until 2011. Though this could reflect their overall scarcity in numbers, or strong placement among ethnic enclaves by the party. Most ethnic minorities hover around 30% win rates, meaning that of the minority groups that run, roughly only one third will win. White candidates fared slightly better, typically rising above most other minorities. However, overall there does not appear to be a trend toward any particular minority group gaining significantly more seats over time. The win rates appear quite sporadic, reflecting the idea that win rates are tied at least in part to placement, not just voter bias toward the candidate.



This bar graph shows the overall percentage of candidates across all election years belonging to each ethnic group. White candidates are clearly the largest group by a very significant amount, however as earlier graphs showed, the gap between the percentage of minority and non-minority MPs has slowly been closing in recent years.



The Liberal Party is traditionally thought of as being the preferred party for immigrants. However, the NDP Party has the largest overall share of minority candidates, at 22%. The Liberal Party is not far behind, at 21%. It is again important to consider that certain parties like the Bloc Quebecois may have much fewer minority candidates due to their limited number of ridings (concentrated within Quebec). However this may also reflect a desire to cater to Quebec nationalism.



Throughout the majority of the last two decades, the Liberal Party has had the highest minority candidate win rate of all the parties. The number of Liberal minority candidates who win out of all Liberal minority candidates is visually striking, especially in 2015 when the number reached its peak at 89%. This means that out of all the minority candidates the Liberal party was running, 89% won their seat. This is shockingly high considering the white win rate never rises much above 30%. Nonetheless, the second highest win rate seems to consistently be the Conservative Party, with the NDP catching up only in 2011. It is possible that voter bias could be playing a role here, especially regarding immigrants and many minorities favouring the Liberal Party. However, party positioning of candidates may also have a hand in the Liberal Party's dominant win rates since 2011.

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. regress won_final ib11. ethnicity_recoded

      Source |       SS           df       MS      Number of obs   =    13,193
-------------+----------------------------------   F(14, 13178)    =      5.87
       Model |  15.2411654        14  1.08865467   Prob > F        =    0.0000
    Residual |   2442.2425    13,178   .18532725   R-squared       =    0.0062
-------------+----------------------------------   Adj R-squared   =    0.0051
       Total |  2457.48367    13,192  .186285906   Root MSE        =     .4305

------------------------------------------------------------------------------
        won_final |      Coef.   Std. Err.      t    P>|t|     [95% Conf. Interval]
------------------+-----------------------------------------------------------
ethnicity_recoded |
            black |   -.106758   .0229439    -4.65   0.000    -.1517315   -.0617846
             arab |  -.0343933   .0324443    -1.06   0.289    -.0979887    .0292022
          chinese |   .0209041   .0289364     0.72   0.470    -.0358154    .0776236
         filipino |  -.1199259   .0800492    -1.50   0.134    -.2768339    .0369821
       indigenous |  -.0486879    .023416    -2.08   0.038    -.0945865   -.0027893
         japanese |   .1421431   .1361984     1.04   0.297    -.1248255    .4091116
           korean |  -.2193954   .0845296    -2.60   0.009    -.3850856   -.0537052
   latin_american |  -.1804376   .0348273    -5.18   0.000    -.2487042    -.112171
      othervismin |  -.1257815   .0592792    -2.12   0.034    -.2419772   -.0095857
      south_asian |  -.0177177   .0152407    -1.16   0.245    -.0475918    .0121563
  southeast_asian |  -.1009942   .0604248    -1.67   0.095    -.2194354     .017447
       west_asian |  -.0469194   .0382773    -1.23   0.220    -.1219485    .0281096
          unknown |  -.2578569   .0918763    -2.81   0.005    -.4379477   -.0777662
       other_mena |  -.2578569   .1077044    -2.39   0.017    -.4689731   -.0467408
                  |
             _cons |   .2578569   .0041573    62.03   0.000      .249708    .2660059
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Lastly, I ran a regression of ethnicity on the winner variable. The majority of the p-values in the first column are not statistically significant ($p < 0.05$) enough to conclude that that ethnic group has a much lower chance of being elected (compared to white candidates, the base group, who win 25.7% of the time). However, groups such as Arabs, Chinese, Indigenous, South Asians and West Asians all had significant p-values. This indicates that they do experience significantly lower chances of winning compared to white candidates. Furthermore, an R-squared value of 0.0062 indicates that ethnicity explains a very small proportion of whether a candidate wins. This, taken with the p-values indicates a need to control for other factors, such as party, province, gender, or incumbency.

Discussion

Overall, this paper has found a lack of clear evidence that minority candidates face worse electoral odds than white candidates based on their ethnicity. A number of other factors may be at play which future research should control for, including party, province, gender, and incumbency. Performing a logistic regression and controlling for these variables may yield clearer results about the way in which ethnicity affects win rates, and perhaps whether voter bias is significantly at play in Canadian elections.

Statistical trends show that minority populations are growing in Canada, and that representation in the House of Commons has not kept pace (Ie 2023). It is important to continue to explore the barriers to political entry that ethnic minority groups face, whether that be voter bias, becoming sacrificial lambs under their party, or a mix of other factors. Future research should continue to explore these relationships, particularly regarding if minorities face difficulties winning elections compared to white candidates based solely on ethnicity.

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